in the US. The amount of money China can spend on the military will be under pressure. Within China's military budget, about 50 per cent of expenditures already go to personnel costs; that figure will increase. Technologically, Beckley argues that AI and automation will change the US's economy. The US, he claims, has five times the number of AI companies and experts as China. This will make American manufacturing and services vastly more efficient and 're-shore' many US businesses (including call centres). China's (and India's) labour cost advantages therefore will slip away. Militarily, the US will be able to replace costly systems with cheap and effective drones and other automated weapons. While China will need a standing army of size to conquer and control areas that it claims, the US will only have to stop Chinese forces. Its AI and automated systems could be decisive in doing that.[15]

In earlier writings, Beckley lists other hurdles facing China: slowing growth, the burgeoning of its debt, dwindling export markets, water and food scarcities, labour protests, and elite emigration, among others. At the same time, he estimates that the US stock of 'produced capital' (that is, machines), human capital, and natural capital (that is, natural resources) will further outdistance China's in the decades ahead.[16] He notes, too, the US's geographical advantage: it is separated from its rivals by the oceans and is unthreatened in its hemisphere. At the same time, the US transcends its geography through hundreds of bases and facilities abroad and a freewheeling navy.[17] The worry for Beckley is not Chinese hegemony but rather increasing domestic troubles in China leading to growing aggression abroad.[18] The US can counter this in East Asia by continuing its alliance with Japan, by drawing in militarily to protect only its closest allies in the region, and by defending others on a strictly transactional basis.[19]

That the US will continue to be the greatest power will be reassuring to India, which has no prospect of catching up with China in the foreseeable future. Given the power gap with China, India must rely on what international relations scholars call 'external balancing', that is, alliances and strategic partnerships. But, as Beckley notes, a dominant US may be increasingly reluctant to come to the aid of others. Given its self-sufficiency